Adventure, Esotericism, and the Buddha:
The Nepali Thangka Market under Neocolonialism Mechanisms

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Figure 1. Street view in Thamel, Kathmandu

Abstract:

My project aims to analyze how tourist art consumption practices influence the Nepali and Himalayan art market, specifically the Thangka Paintings. It explores the interactions between local artists/dealers and tourists, mediated through galleries, museums, and Thangka academies, to study the complexities of local cultural heritage preservation under global pressures.

Figure 2. Thangka shops in Thamel, Kathmandu

Figure 3. Buddha Acala

Tourism & Over-commercialization:

After the 2000s, tourism in Nepal has grown to be unsustainable. An excessive influx of tourists has tempted overmuch Nepalese to abandon traditional industries and seek opportunities in the tourism market. Thangka shops, alongside hotels, travel agents, and souvenir shops, bloomed in the major cities of Nepal (Figure 1&2). With the supply overgrowing the demand, problems of business competition, price war, and quality control is now troubling this market.

Figure 4. Rohan (below) and Ratnakumar (above)

Generational Conflict and Brain Drain:

Being part of the Thangka business is often a generational heritage, but the younger generation wants to be free of this legacy. Rohan Lama (Figure 4), one of my interviewees, expressed that he want to study computer science in the U.S., while his father, Ratnakumar Lama, was rather confident that Rohan would inherit the shop.

Further, many experienced Thangka artists have migrated to developed countries to either continue their careers there or to serve as instructors/consultants for other art institutions for better payment.

Figure 5. A Thangka in-progress and its finished comparison

Mass Production vs. Craftsmanship:

While a fully hand-painted Thangka takes months or even years to make, utilizing modern technology could reduce this cycle significantly. Some works use chemical pigments instead of natural pigments, while some are called “half-prints” – meaning that various parts of this piece (in most cases the initial sketch) were done by a printer.